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“The Conjugal Dictatorship”

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Chapter I of *The Conjugal Dictatorship* by Primitivo Mejares gives a critical look at the political and diplomatic strategies used by Ferdinand Marcos during his rule, especially in relation to his dealings with the United States. The power, diplomacy, and corruption which characterize this regime are, in fact, the bases for the writing of *The Conjugal Dictatorship* by Primitivo Mejares.

Mejares (1976) describes how Marcos changed the political situation to gain US support for his rule. When Marcos visited Washington D.C., he portrayed the Philippines as a friend in the battle against communism. Mejares points out that Marcos did not portray his government as a strong defense against communism. Rather, it was portrayed as if communism was a real threat to democracy in the region.

Marcos's speech relates to the U.S. government's concern about the spread of communism in Asia, especially after the Vietnam War. Through that concern, Marcos was able to garner much economic and military aid, which enhanced his authority in the country. Mejares (1976) This foreign policy not only advances foreign relations but also propels Marcos's powers during his reign.

The Philippines was not exempted during this phase of the Cold War; instead, it highly affected the relations between the Philippines and the United States. Mejares (1976) contends that, with the concentration of the U.S. focus on preventing communism from spreading to Southeast Asia and, of course, the Philippines, with its strategic location and most important military bases, Clark Air Base and Subic Bay, became a handy ally. Historian Alfred W. McCoy noted in 2009, "The United States simply decided to look away from the authoritarian regime of President

Marcos because it required an anti-communist partner in Asia that was stable in the region." Such a Cold War setting defined U.S.-Philippine relations and the Philippines' political landscape. Marcos used anti-communism as a reason for declaring Martial Law in 1972 by describing the necessity to remove communists, but he also used this declaration to crush political opponents and rule without legal bounds.

Marcos went to Washington, D.C., and it really helped his politics. Mejares (1976) said that having the U.S. on his side was important for Marcos to stay in power during the early years of Martial Law. The U.S. gave him money and military support, which allowed him to take stronger action against the military and police—this was very important for him to stay in control. Some international respect that support from the United States gave Marcos made it difficult for others to speak against him, both in the Philippines and externally.

The impact of the U.S. changed the policies in the Philippines. Due to the backing of the American military and finance, Marcos acquired more power over the military and police. He utilized this power to suppress opposition leaders and shape the press. As McCoy (2009) reports, the aid from America enabled people of the Philippines to create a culture that they used their power without facing consequences. According to Mejares (1976), during the Marcos' government, corruption and other wild acts from this administration were hidden by the U.S. and caused economic damage and subsequently weakened democratic institutions.

The support given by the U.S. for Marcos is a matter of moral questions. Mejares (1976) attacks the U.S. for allowing its anti-communist fight to take precedence over the welfare of the Filipino people while aiding a government that repressed human rights. There were millions of Filipinos who, while busy with their campaign against communism, lost their freedoms. It raises questions about what the powerful nations should do when their efforts aid the governments of authoritarianism.

Mejares (1976) says that international diplomacy can greatly affect a country's internal matters. In the Philippines, Marcos was able to keep his strict control because he got support from the U.S. This support made it easier for him to weaken

democracy and silence those who disagreed with him. U.S. aid helped Marcos show that his government was stable and legitimate, even though many Filipinos were unhappy.

The story of Marcos dictatorship shows how power, corruption, and diplomacy can be related. Mejares (1976) infers that Marcos kept his power through his relationship with the U.S. This allowed him to mask corruption and human rights violations and gain legitimacy for staying in power. Here, Marcos declared Martial Law over himself, thus showcasing the other end of the spectrum of power being abused in the name of national security.

Many issues from the Marcos era remain relevant in the global politics of today. Powerful countries continue to back authoritarian governments for strategic interests, even if such governments disregard human rights. These actions lead to ethical dilemmas, where states balance their interests with promises made to advance democracy and human rights.

Looking back, one is hard put to explain why the United States supported the Marcos government and the human rights abuses and the closing down of democratic institutions. During the Cold War, communism must be fought but the U.S. need not necessarily stop the democratic changes while keeping the alliance strong.

If the U.S. was sterner on human rights, things could have taken another twist in the Philippines. Had not the U.S. been keeping him on their side, Marcos would not have remained in power for such a long time, and the country might have become democratic in time enough. According to Mejares (1976), U.S. support was very vital for Marcos to stay in power.

In short, Chapter I of *The Conjugal Dictatorship* shows how international relations can greatly affect local politics, usually with serious effects for the people in those countries.

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